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CASE STUDY · GEN Z FI CONCEPT

The Process Behind the Pitch

From research to a live, working prototype.

Fabian Wong, Product Designer

01 · CONTEXT

The brief & my role

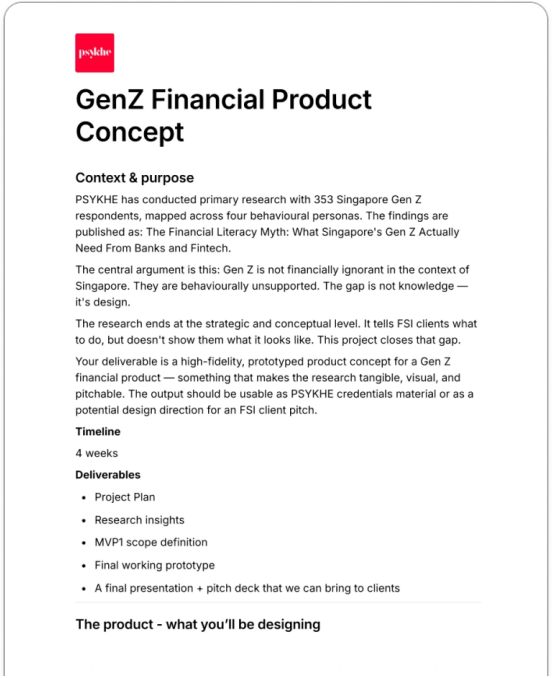
A self-driven financial-intelligence concept project, run with PSYKHE embedded inside a major bank. The remit: prove whether a behavioural layer could help Gen Z stay on track — built far enough to test, not just describe.

I owned the work end to end, solo — from framing and primary research through prototyping, usability testing and the final pitch.

Scope, end to end

Research · Synthesis · Prototyping · Usability testing · Pitch · Solo-led

THE BRIEF



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GenZ Financial Product Concept

Context & purpose

PSYKHE has conducted primary research with 353 Singapore Gen Z respondents, mapped across four behavioural personas. The findings are published as: The Financial Literacy Myth: What Singapore's Gen Z Actually Need From Banks and Fintech.

The central argument is this: Gen Z is not financially ignorant in the context of Singapore. They are behaviourally unsupported. The gap is not knowledge — it's design.

The research ends at the strategic and conceptual level. It tells FSI clients what to do, but doesn't show them what it looks like. This project closes that gap.

Your deliverable is a high-fidelity, prototyped product concept for a Gen Z financial product — something that makes the research tangible, visual, and pitchable. The output should be usable as PSYKHE credentials material or as a potential design direction for an FSI client pitch.

Timeline

4 weeks

Deliverables

- Project Plan
- Research insights
- MVP1 scope definition
- Final working prototype
- A final presentation + pitch deck that we can bring to clients

The product - what you'll be designing

Project plan & documentation — Coda ↗

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02 · PLAN

Planning the approach

The plan ran **27 April to 3 August** — six phases, each closing its tasks before the next began.

PHASE 01
27 Apr – 10 May

Set-up & Recruitment

- Onboarding & Coda workspace
- Recruitment posts — LinkedIn, IG, Telegram
- Dry run & iterate

PHASE 02
4 – 18 May

Research

- 7 user-interview sessions
- Deep-read PSYKHE article

PHASE 03
18 May – 1 Jun

Synthesis & Direction

- Cluster quotes, validate / reject hypotheses
- Persona from 7 candidates
- Kano matrix → pick direction & brand

PHASE 04
28 May – 20 Jun

Prototype Build

- Bank library references — Figma & Google
- Claude Design / Figma Make / Google Stitch experiments

PHASE 05
8 Jun – 15 Jul

Validate & Iterate

- Usability test hi-fi — 3 returning + 1 new
- Iterate on feedback
- Fix critical issues

PHASE 06
15 Jul – 3 Aug

The Pitch

- Build pitch deck
- Rehearse — record, review, refine
- Final presentation to PSYKHE

Planned vs actual

Interviews, synthesis, prototype build, usability testing and iterations each ran longer than scoped — so the end date moved from June to July to protect the quality of the work.



Coda project board ↗

03 · RESEARCH DESIGN

Objectives & hypotheses

44.2%

Problem. After deep-reading PSYKHE's Gen Z finance article, I took the "Trying-to-Be-Good" segment — 44.2%, financially conscious but derailed by situational triggers — into research. The challenge: structural support that keeps them on track without feeling restrictive.

Why "Trying-to-Be-Good" · PSYKHE article ↗

RO1
Validate the behavioural pattern.

RO2
Identify which intervention resonates.

RO3
Find the friction threshold.

RO4
Understand what builds trust.

Research objectives RO1–4 · Coda ↗

Five hypotheses to test

Hypotheses board · FigJam ↗

H1 · Payday default interception
Auto-move a set slice of salary into a savings pocket on payday — the failure point is execution friction, not intent.

H2 · BNPL cooldown toggle
Opt-in 24-hour cooldown on BNPL above a set threshold — impulse-driven purchases cool within a day.

H3 · Spending-pattern alert
Flag when a transaction or daily total exceeds the usual pattern — awareness at the moment beats post-spend summaries.

H4 · Lump-sum confirmation pause
Large one-off buys trigger a brief impact check — invisible money feels cheaper (the "pain of paying").

H5 · Social accountability layer
Share a streak or goal with 1–2 friends — 92% of respondents are motivated by peer visibility.

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04 · RECRUITMENT

Recruitment & calibration

Recruitment — the pivot

PLANNED CHANNELS — EACH STALLED

~~LinkedIn~~	few Singaporean Gen Z on the platform
~~Instagram~~	audience was mostly millennial friends
~~Telegram~~	groups needed research qualification to post

PIVOTED TO TIKTOK

@fabian.n8n

1,015 followers · 3,121 likes — an audience that skews Gen Z

DM'd my own followers directly → real interview responses.

TikTok · @fabian.n8n ↗

DRY RUN & CALIBRATION

Ran a dry run with a colleague, **Shin**, before any real session — and rewrote the guide off what it exposed:

— Ask about the last real time it happened, not the typical case.

— Drop hypothetical *"would you"* → ask **"walk me through."**

Interview guide & dry run · FigJam ↗

INCENTIVE

S$10 Grab voucher for the interview (round 1), plus a potential round 2 — usability testing — at a further **S$10**.

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05 · METHOD

Designing the study

Screener & filter logic

A 2-minute screener qualified people on self-ID, regret frequency and app usage — before any interview slot was offered.

Q2 + Q6 = Yes	Singapore-based & comfortable being recorded
Q3 = B or C	self-IDs as derailed by temptation / spends to cope
Q4 ≥ 1–2× / month	prioritised anyone reporting purchase regret
Q5 ≥ 1 bank + 1 BNPL	can speak to the core money behaviours

Screener survey · Notion ↗

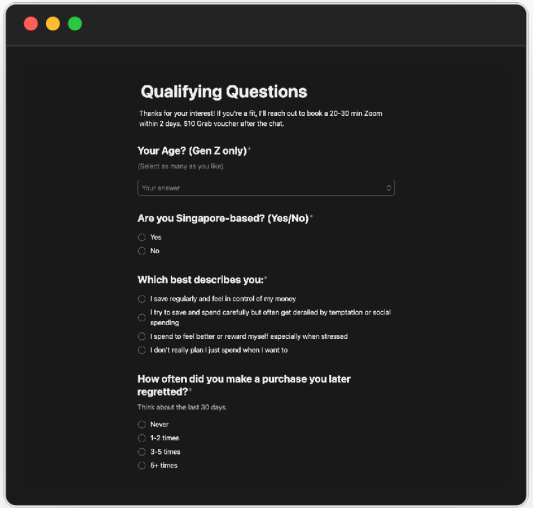
Screener responses · 8 qualified

All SG-based Gen Z **All OK to record**

Age	**18–28, across all three bands**
Banking app	**6 / 8 same bank**
Regret frequency	**skews 5+ / month**

Screened out — "save regularly / in control" and "never regret" responses, which sit outside the target moment.

The screener itself



Built & hosted in Notion — 8 qualifying questions, ~2 min to complete.

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06 · FIELDWORK

Running & synthesising **7 interviews**

Updated participant map

P1 Hendrix	Partial	H3 bank alert changed behaviour
P2 Chin Ern	Low	H3 welcomes recommendations
P3 Cody	Partial	H3 GXS limit + tracker abandonment
P4 Kaeden	Strong	H1 + H3 + sustained derailment
P5 John	Moderate	H1 save-first + H3 visual goal
P6 Zhi Kai	Strong	H3 unprompted feature + self-override
P7 Nicholas	Strong	H5 accountability + H1 + H3

P1 partial — authenticity flag · P2 low — persona mismatch, kept as contrast data.

IN SESSION · REMOTE & MODERATED



POST-MORTEM AFTER EVERY SESSION

Claude generated a post-mortem from each transcript — an honest grade plus technique fixes (dig into the gold moments, kill "would you" hypotheticals, stop leading with options) so the next session ran sharper.

RIGOUR

Self-graded every session and treated the P1 / P2 flags as contrast data — sharpening technique session over session rather than counting all seven as equal evidence.

MVP PRIORITY **H3** spending alert / auto-categorise — 7 / 7 › **H1** payday interception — 5 / 7 strong › **H5** social accountability — V2, anchored by P7

Synthesis & participant map · FigJam ↗

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07 · SYNTHESIS

From insight to persona



Ryan Lim

24 · Singapore
Software engineer

INCOME	SAVES	ACTUAL
S$4,200/mo	30% target	18–22%

Disciplined on paper — 70/30 split, weekly spreadsheet. In practice the system breaks 2–3× a month: a TikTok ad at midnight, a flash sale, drinks after dinner.

"I have the system. I just don't have the discipline to stick to it every single time."

Target the moment, not the identity.

No one is a "bad saver" all the time — everyone slips in specific, **triggered moments**. Design for the moment and one feature serves every persona; design for a fixed identity and it serves almost none.

Traits

- Tech-savvy — juggles multiple money apps
- Wants to see patterns, not be lectured
- Values autonomy; rejects anything controlling

Pain points

- No real-time visibility — sees damage end-of-month
- Manual tracking never sustains past a few weeks
- Payday savings sit unprotected; willpower breaks

Goals

- Save consistently without relying on willpower
- Money managed automatically, not by logging
- Early nudges before month-end surprises

HOW MIGHT WE

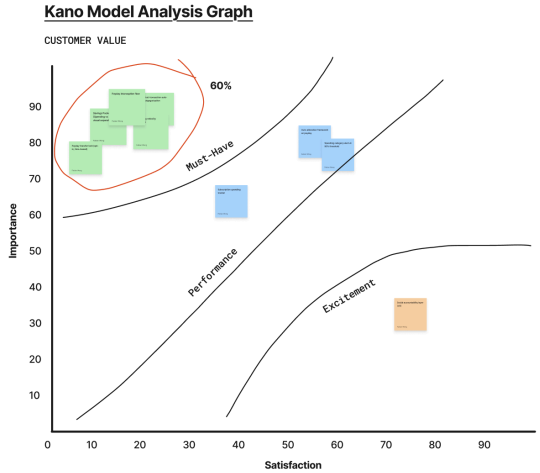
Help Gen Z with financial intent but inconsistent execution stay on track — with real-time behavioural support inside their existing banking app, without feeling restrictive or adding manual effort.

Persona & HMW · FigJam ↗

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08 · PRIORITISATION

Prioritisation — the Kano model



Must-Have: if it's missing, users notice and get frustrated. If it's there, they barely notice — they just expect it.
Performance: the better this works, the happier users are. No ceiling — more investment keeps paying off.
Excitement: users don't miss it if absent, but it delights them if present — what makes an app feel thoughtful, not just functional.

Why these five scored highest opportunity

Both sides of Opportunity = Importance × (1 − Satisfaction / 100) worked against the bank. Importance was rated highest across the 7 interviews — the behaviours participants most needed support with — while satisfaction was lowest, since the bank offers none of them today. High importance plus low satisfaction is exactly what the formula surfaces, so this cluster fell out of the scoring, not a judgment call.

Why satisfaction is so low

The bank offers none of these today. Savings Pockets scores lowest (15) — no pocket or vault system exists. Payday Transfer Lock is lower still (10); self-imposed savings locks don't exist in any SG bank app.

Opportunity = Importance × (1 − Satisfaction / 100)

MUST-HAVE

Expected basics — absence causes dissatisfaction, presence is barely noticed.

1 Auto-categorisation · 2 Payday Interception · 3 Savings Pockets · 4 Spending Velocity · 5 Payday Transfer Lock

PERFORMANCE

More is better — satisfaction scales linearly with how well it's done.

6 Auto-allocation framework · 7 Category alert (90%) · 8 Subscription tracker

EXCITEMENT

Unexpected delight — absence isn't missed, presence wins loyalty.

9 Social accountability (V2)

Full prioritisation matrix · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

09 · IDEATION

Flows first, sketches second.

STAGE 1 · MAPPING THE LOGIC

Flow 1 · Payday Interception · Savings Pockets · Transfer Lock

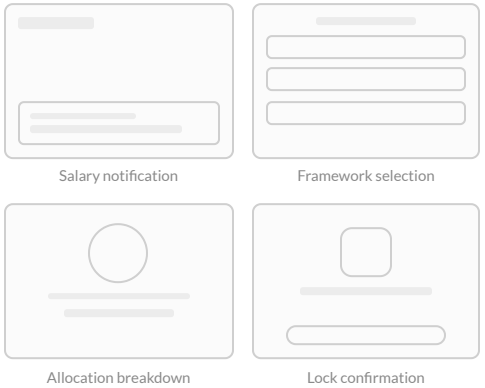
1 Salary hits account → 2 Push notification fires →
3 User picks framework → 4 Money splits into pocket → 5 Lock offered

Flow 2 · Post-transaction Auto-Categorisation

1 User taps card → 2 LLM matches merchant → 3 Auto-tags category →
4 View breakdown anytime

Three entry points mapped first — payday notification, spending-exceeds, and manual opt-out — each with explicit branches before a single pixel was drawn.

STAGE 2 · SKETCHING THE SCREENS



Every flow node became a wireframe — covering the payday opt-in, spending-exceeds alert, and manual opt-out paths.

STAGE 3 · REFINING THROUGH REVIEW

Payday flow — auto-apply the chosen framework on later paydays (re-picking monthly recreates the friction that killed old apps); only recurring income triggers it, not refunds or P2P.

Spending-exceeds flow — move the unlock from point-of-sale to pre-purchase in-app, turning a public moment private; sketch online checkout separately from in-store.

Opt-out flow — add a confirmation ("your lock helps you stay on track") and let opt-out take effect tomorrow, not instantly. The friction is the feature.

Missing states — day-7 lock-release "small win" nudge, first-time empty state, edit-framework mid-month, biometric-failure fallback (PIN / cool-down).

Auto-categorisation — one drawer, two headers ("Change category" vs "Help us categorise this"); notification reads "Tap to change" vs "Tap to categorise".

Logic came first, screens came second — and every gap surfaced in review before a single flow reached hi-fi.

Feature flows & sketches · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

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10 · TOOLING

Choosing the right AI tool

Direction first. Before testing tools, I asked Claude which route would give the highest-fidelity prototype for testing. Its recommendation: build in Claude Design, hand off to Claude Code, deploy on Vercel — skipping the conventional Figma prototype flow entirely.

Then a fair test. Three AI tools were run against the same bank brand file and the same sketches, each fed the same FigJam flows (Flow 1, Flow 2, Flow A/B/C) from the 22 Jun sketch set. Judged on how the output actually landed, not the demo.

Figma Make
FAST EXPLORATION

Quick to spin variations, but drifted from the bank brand file. Good for breadth, not fidelity.

SELECTED

Claude Design
CLOSEST VISUAL ACCURACY

Held the bank brand and component structure most faithfully across every screen. Brand fidelity and component accuracy were the deciding factors.

Google Stitch
QUICK LAYOUT IDEAS

Handy for rough layout starts, but generic styling meant heavy rework to feel on-brand.

Once Claude Design won, screens were iterated directly there, then handed off to Claude Code for the working build — covered next.

Tool comparison · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

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11 · BUILD

Building the prototype

Claude Design
screens built

→

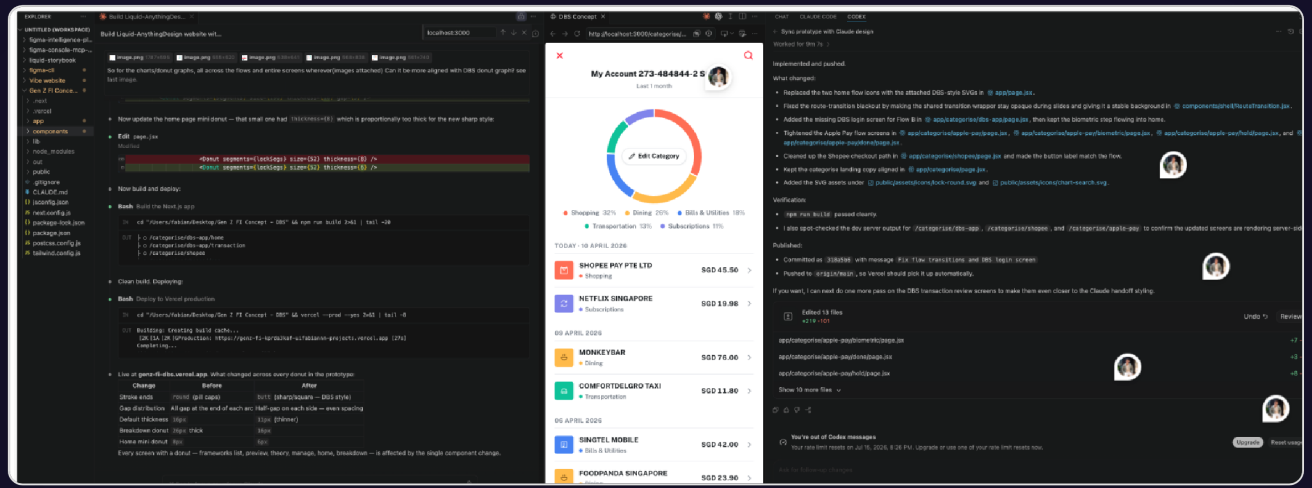
~~Figma handoff~~
skipped for the build

→

Claude Code × VS Code × Codex × GitHub × Vercel
plan · prompt · build · verify · deploy

Sonnet 4.6

GPT-5.4-mini



22 JUN · INTERNAL REVIEW

Sofiah ran a prototype feedback round with Charmaine, walking every branch — **Flow 1, Flow 2** and **Flow A / B / C** — before formal usability testing began.

Annotated directly in FigJam, so fixes were logged against the live build, not a static mock.

http://localhost:3000/ → genz-fi.vercel.app LIVE

Build & review board · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

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12 · QA

Internal review before testing

A lightweight review round on **22 June** — walking the two main flows with colleague input before any formal usability session.

Payday Interception

- Opt-in → lock configured
- Goal attached → release schedule
- Override → unlock path

Auto-Categorisation

- Spending breakdown → category detail
- Tap transaction → recategorise
- Search & filter → refined view

DRY RUN FIRST · SANDRA

Ran a full dry run with **Sandra** before any formal session — pressure-testing the script and timing so real participants met a clean, rehearsed protocol.

MODERATION COACHING · CHARMAINE

Charmaine sat in and sharpened the facilitation:

- Stay silent at least **5 seconds** after every response — let the participant fill the gap.
- It's fine to **follow the script for the opening** to keep every session's start consistent and smooth.

FRAMING & QUESTION ORDER

Framing matters — and the **sequence stays consistent** across sessions, since Payday Lock and Auto-Categorisation work hand in hand and shape each other's responses.

Outcome — each sub-flow confirmed navigable and labelled before testing; issues logged as build fixes, not open questions.

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13 · VALIDATION

Usability testing — round 2

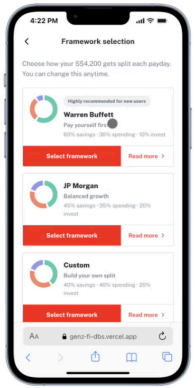
This round was **validation, not discovery** — testing whether the built prototype actually solved the original pain points.

Zhi Kai	Cody	Kaeden	Bryan
Returning	Returning	Returning	New

METHOD

Moderated, scenario-based, flow order counterbalanced — and feature names were never spoken by the moderator, so comprehension had to come from the interface alone.

Run over Microsoft Teams with participant face cam on, so reactions and hesitation were visible alongside what they clicked. The prototype was opened in a separate browser window and screen-shared, keeping the call and the interface distinct. Teams' auto-generated transcript was used for synthesis afterward, cross-checked against the recording.





Participant · driving the flow



Moderator · observing

Usability testing plan & script · Coda ↗

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14 · FINDINGS

What testing revealed

0 / 4

Auto-categorisation is the hero. Zero comprehension failures across all four sessions.

THE KAEDEN PARADOX

In his interview Kaeden overspent the most — Pokémon cards, TikTok Live impulse buys. In testing he called himself **disciplined** and said a lock would annoy him enough to quit the app.

Behaviour says one thing, self-image another. A lock only works if you opt in — but the people who need it most won't admit it. So **target the moment, not the identity.**

Five patterns, not opinions

Findings that now repeat across both sessions.

1. **Notification reads as an ad** and gets ignored first — the most repeated finding and a real adoption risk. Make the entry point read as a feature, not marketing.
2. **"Tap to change" is too small.** Both flagged it — make recategorising a prominent action.
3. **The breakdown isn't sticky.** Both looked once and left (Cody rated 2.5/5 to return) — it needs a reason to come back, or reads as a light feature.
4. **The override should be deliberate.** Zhi Kai wanted it; Cody asked for a double-confirm unprompted — design the override as a conscious step.
5. **Verbose framework text & duplicate buttons.** Both flagged it — trim copy, remove repeated CTAs.

Testing findings board · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

Prioritising the fixes



Phase 1 · iterate now Phase 2 · defer Plotted Importance × Satisfaction — same as the first Kano; top-left is the must-fix zone.

Phase 1 — iterate now

1 Goal-linked framing — highest leverage; 3 of 4 asked, Charmaine endorsed, aligns with the article. Reframes the lock from restriction to motivation. **2 Search + filter** — makes categorisation a daily tool, not a monthly glance. **3 Deliberate override** — existential for the lock; all 4 flagged it. **4–8 Quick wins** — tap-to-change prominence, spendable-balance clarity, rename/recolour, framework polish. Cheap, all remove real friction.

Phase 2 — defer

9 Inflow / income view — softer evidence; Bryan's was partly moderator-prompted. **10 Extend to PayNow** — real value, high complexity. **11 Export to Excel / PDF** — power-user, mildly works against retention. **12 Velocity copy** — low stakes.

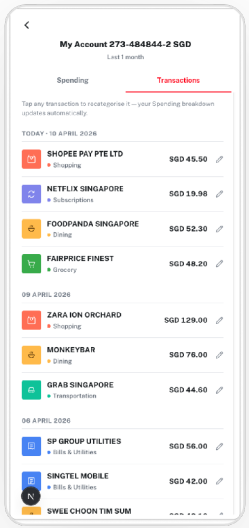
Fix prioritisation board · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

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16 · ITERATION

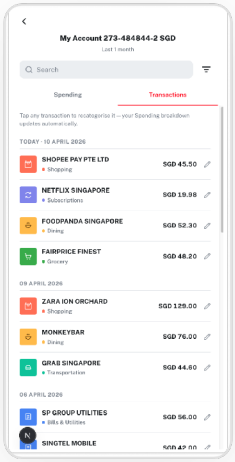
From insights to iterations — **search, filter & lock framing**

BEFORE

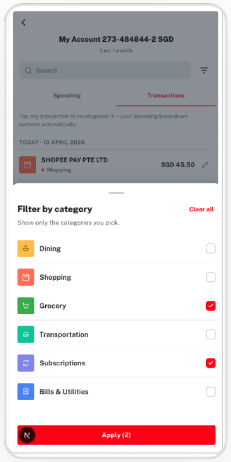


Scroll-only list. No way to find one transaction or focus a category.

AFTER · SEARCH, FILTER & LOCK FRAMING

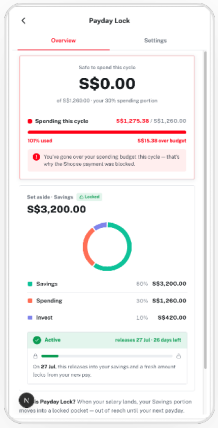


Search + filter added to the header.



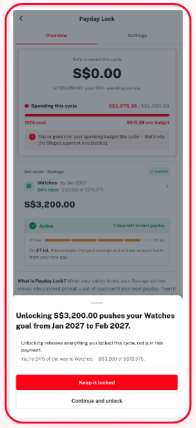
Filter by category — pick any set.

LOCK · BEFORE



Neutral release — unlocking reads as a routine, consequence-free action.

LOCK · AFTER



Goal-linked framing — "pushes your Watches goal to Feb 2027," default is **Keep it locked**.

Framing changed the outcome. Naming the real cost — a delayed goal, not just an unlocked amount — and making "Keep it locked" the prominent choice reframes the moment from friction to motivation, nudging Gen Z users to leave their savings locked.

Before / after board · figma.com/board/H2CDZt5s8MO1JR3bZd6LLK ↗

17 · THE PITCH

A 16–18 slide pitch, and a live, working prototype.

genz-fi.vercel.app

- View the pitch deck · Claude Design ↗

With thanks to **Sofiah** for direction and stakeholder review throughout.